



SUVASHIS MULLICK



SITTING MP: Dawa Narbula (Cong)

The main candidates this time:

Jaswant Singh (BJP)

Dawa Narbula (Congress)

Jibesh Sarkar (CPI-M)

Male voters: 8 lakh (approx.)

Female voters: 4 lakh (approx.)

Polling date: April 30

"IF MANMOHAN SINGH IS AN INSIDER IN Assam, how can I be an outsider in Darjeeling?"

JASWANT SINGH, *BJP leader*

Advani six months back that I would like to contest the polls this time. I thought it would be natural for me to get a seat from Rajasthan... either my home seat from which my son, Manvendra, is now contesting, or Jodhpur or even Jhalore. Things were quiet for sometime and I did not want to be a bad father and ask Manvendra not to contest. Then Advani said that the party couldn't afford to let me go (as leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha). Now I realised that with me in the Rajya Sabha and Manvendra contesting for the Lok Sabha, it would look as if the father-son duo was sort of usurping the right to be in Parliament. So I kept quiet."

It was then that the Morcha came

with a list of three names, those of Advani, Sushma Swaraj and Singh. "Advaniji wanted me and I said yes, I would love to go to the hills but only if my partners, the Morcha and other allies, support me. No decision was thrust upon me. And so, here I am."

His rallies and roadshows at Kalimpong and Darjeeling with a meeting thrown in at Mungpoo, an hour's drive from Kalimpong uphill, smack of contrasts. Singh speaks with a soft baritone while his main lieutenant Gurung takes the stage in the end and takes the people by storm. "I will resign if I do not get Gorkhaland by 2010," thunders Gurung while Singh elaborates on the rationale in sophisticated Hindi. "If the NDA comes

to power, we are committed to the cause of Gorkhaland. It will be our bounden duty and my personal obligation to the people here. It is part of the BJP manifesto." Will the CPI(M) ever listen to the Gorkhaland demand? He looks squarely and his jaw tightens. "Will you please allow me to cross that bridge when it comes?"

His opponents have taken him to task for saying that he would love to be a *ghar-jamai* in Darjeeling. And who would be the bride, we ask. The Singh, who may be the king soon, smiles broadly, "The Queen of the Hills. Darjeeling, naturally!" ■

For Jaswant Singh interview, click to:
www.indiatoday.in/jaswant

